

Relic syntax and dialectal comparison: the adjectival article in early West Germanic

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Towards a comparative historical dialectology:
evidence from morphology and syntax
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Aims of this talk

- ▶ Present facts about adjectival articles (based on North Germanic)
- ▶ Argue that early West Germanic languages also display evidence for incipient adjectival article use
- ▶ Provide evidence for the above claim from early West Germanic
- ▶ Make the case that this adjectival article is a relic feature in Germanic

Modern Scandinavian

Freestanding article mandatory if noun phrase contains adjective:

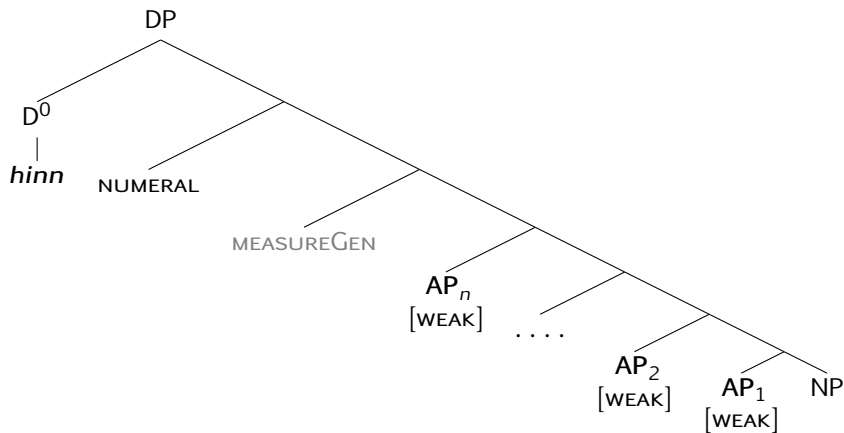
- (1) **den** *(gul-a) bilen (Swed)
 DET *yellow-wk car.the*
- (2) **den** *(gul-e) bil (Dan)
 DET *yellow-wk car*
- (3) **den** *(gul-e) bilen (Norw)
 DET *yellow-wk car.the*

all: “the yellow car”

- (4) **hin** *(fræg-a) leikkona (Ice)
 ART *famous-wk actress*
 “the famous actress”

Widespread agreement: *den/hinn* are high determiners.

Modern Icelandic: structure



Examples that superficially look like Modern Icelandic:

- (5) **hinn** blindi maður

ART *blind-wk man*

(MÍM: Heimskringla)

- (6) **hins** bannaða eplis

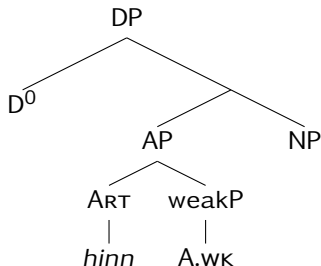
ART *forbidden-wk apple*

(IcePaHC: 1350.MARTA.REL-SAG)

BUT: syntactic status/position is not the same! The Olce *hinn* forms a constituent with the adjective to the exclusion of the noun (Nygaard, 1906; Stroh-Wollin, 2009, 2015; Börjars & Payne, 2016; Börjars et al., 2016; Pfaff, 2019)

Adjectival article: structure

Pfaff (2019, 198):



- ▶ The Noun Phrases in Early Germanic Languages (NPEGL) database
 - ▶ Created as part of the RCN project 'Constraints on syntactic variation: noun phrases in early Germanic languages'
 - ▶ Contains Gothic, Old English, Old High German, Old Icelandic, and Old Saxon noun phrases
- ▶ Old Icelandic: MÍM *Fornrit*
- ▶ Old English: YCOEP (Pintzuk & Plug, 2001)
- ▶ Old High German: *Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*

Arguments for adjectival article, 1

Weak adjectives and *hinn* (basically) occur in lockstep:
“definiteness” is not a sufficient explanation

- ▶ adjectives do not automatically occur weakly inflected when accompanied by definite elements (like demonstratives and possessives)
- ▶ Pfaff (2019), building on Börjars & Payne (2016): weak adjectives are “defective”, or “incomplete” APs
- ▶ *(h)inn* is an “adjectival complementizer” that, by merging with a weak adjective, produces a “complete” adjectival phrase: $[_{xAP} (h)inn [_{weakP} A.wk]]$

Arguments for adjectival article, 2

Weak sequences (*hinn* + adj) and strong adjectives in complementary distribution

(7) minn **hinn** best-i vin
my ART *best*-WK *friend*
(MÍM: Íslendinga þættir)

(8) hans **ina** björt-u frægð
his ART *illustrious*-WK *fame*
(Olce.100.538)

(9) gullhring sínum **hinum** góð-a
goldring POSS ART *good*-WK
(MÍM: Harðar saga)

(10) karfi hans **hinn** stór-i
ship *his* ART *big*-WK
(Olce.488.876)

(11) sinni fullkomin-**ni** vináttu
POSS *perfect*-STR *friendship*
(MÍM: Sturlunga saga)

(12) vors heilag-s föður
our *holy*-STR *father*
(Olce.558.908)

(13) öxi sína forn-a
axe POSS *old*-STR
(MÍM: Sturlunga saga)

(14) brauð vort yfirveranleg-t
bread *our* *spiritual*-STR
(Olce.923.674)

Arguments for adjectival article, 3

With multiple adjectives, *hinn* occurs once per adjective.

- (15) **hinn** hraustasti og **hinn** vaskasti drengur
 ART *energetic.SUPL.WK* og ART *brave.SUPL.WK* lad
 ‘the most energetic and bravest young man’
 (MÍM: Gunnlaugs saga ormstungu)

What about early West Germanic languages?

- ▶ No cognate of *hinn* in article function in early West Germanic (eWGmc) languages
 - ▶ Old English (OE)
 - ▶ Old High German (OHG)
 - ▶ Old Saxon (OS)
- ▶ Recent research on OE and OHG suggests that grammaticalization of demonstratives (DEM) as articles was more advanced at this earlier stage than previously thought (Wood, 2007; Sommerer, 2018; Flick, 2020)
- ▶ Is there evidence that they are also grammaticalized (in parallel?) as *adjectival* articles at these early stages?
 - ▶ Our claim: yes!

Arguments for adjectival article in eWGmc

1. DEM and possessives
2. Postnominal DEM
3. Vocatives

- ▶ The Noun Phrases in Early Germanic Languages (NPEGL) database
 - ▶ Created as part of the RCN project 'Constraints on syntactic variation: noun phrases in early Germanic languages'
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- ▶ Old High German: *Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*

1. Demonstratives and possessives

Allen (2006), Wood (2007, §4): nominal word order is pretty fixed in OE already, with very limited possibilities for co-occurrence of possessives and demonstratives prenominally.

- ▶ Demonstrative + Possessive: not hugely common (but also attested in PDE)
- ▶ Possessive + Demonstrative:
 1. does not survive past OE
 2. always occurs with an adjective (cf. Allen, 2006)
 3. only occurs with 'distal' demonstrative (Allen, 2006, 158)

- (16) his þam ecan Fæder
his DEM.DIST eternal father
'his eternal Father' (OEng.813.633)

Demonstratives and possessives

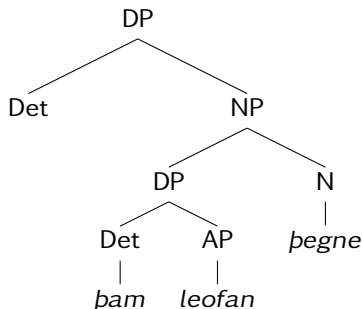
Interesting to compare the C text of Gregory's Dialogues (9th c.) with the revised H text (10th-11th c.) (Allen, 2006, 164; Wood, 2007, 180–181). For examples represented in both:

- ▶ C manuscript: 16 examples of POSS + DEM
- ▶ H manuscript: reviser has changed all 16 – in 11 of them the DEM has been deleted

(17) his þæs clænan lifes
 his DEM.DIST clean life
 'his clean life' (Gregory's Dialogues; OEng.269.358)

Allen's analysis

Allen (2006, 158): “adjective phrases, like noun phrases, have a slot for a determiner”. Tree (Allen, 2006, 159):



Modulo labels, this is the same as the structure found in Pfaff (2019).

- ▶ Doesn't occur at all prenominally in OS NPEGL
 - ▶ BUT! Postnominal `DEM` only ever occurs with an adjective in OS
- ▶ Does occur postnominally (eight examples of the same phrase)

(18) `fro min thie guodo`
 `lord my DEM good-wk`
 (OSax.115.210)

Hard to find in *Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*. But at least two examples are found in Otfrid:

- (19) Drúhtin min ther gúato
lord my DEM good-wk
(*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; O_Otfr.Ev.3.7)
- (20) Múater sin thiū gúata
mother his DEM good-wk
(*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; O_Otfr.Ev.4.32)

Caveat: adjective is part of rhyming couplet in both cases.

Argument 2. Postnominal adjectives

In OS, DEM is usually initial within the nominal constituent (2,000+ examples). DEM may also be found postnominally (33 examples) – BUT only when:

- ▶ followed immediately by a weak adjective
- ▶ distal

- (21) suerdu thiu scarpon
sword DEM sharp-wk
(OSax.622.918)
- (22) himile them hohon
heaven DEM high-wk
(OSax.471.220)
- (23) nadra thiu feha
snake DEM colourful-wk
(OSax.429.338)

No other examples of postnominal weak adjectives.

Postnominal adjectives: OE prose

DEM is never postnominal unless followed by a weak adjective.

- (24) geallancoðe þa readan
 gall-disease DEM red-wk
 (OEng.284.604; Leechbook)
- (25) wermod se hara
 wormwood DEM old-wk
 (OEng.550.650; Lacnunga)
- (26) hælend se Nadzarenisca
 saviour DEM Nazarene-wk
 (OEng.278.039; Vercelli Homilies)

Only one (late, dubious) example of postnominal weak adjective without DEM.

Postnominal adjectives: OE poetry

- (27) sele þam hean
hall DEM high-wk
(YCOEP; cobeowul,23.710.598; there are three additional identical examples)
- (28) beorh þone hean
mountain DEM high-wk
(YCOEP; cobeowul,95.3093.249)
- (29) mægðhad se micla
maidenhood DEM great-wk
(YCOEP; cochrist,5.82.56)
- (30) wyrd seo mære
fate DEM great-wk
(YCOEP; coexeter,136.99.92)

(But the picture is not quite as clear... ask me if interested)

Postnominal adjectives in OHG: Otfrid

Robustly found in Otfrid:

- (31) Múater thiu gúata
mother DEM good-wk
(Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch; O_Otfr.Ev.1.15)
- (32) kúningin thia ríchun
queen DEM rich-wk
(Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch; O_Otfr.Ev.1.3)
- (33) Gímma thiu wíza
gem DEM white-wk
(Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch; O_Otfr.Ev.1.5)
- (34) gótes drut ther máro
God.GEN friend DEM great-wk
(Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch; O_Otfr.Ev.2.7)

Postnominal adjectives in OHG: other texts

- (35) uuiroh daz rota
 incense DEM red-wk
 (*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; BR1_BaslerRezept1)
- (36) uuiroh daz uuizza
 incense DEM white-wk
 (*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; BR1_BaslerRezept1)
- (37) engila dê skônun
 angels DEM beautiful-wk
 (*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; G_Georgslied_Tschirch)

Texts that contain postnominal adjectives are exclusively early (8th and 9th century), but in different scribal dialects.

Argument 3. Vocatives

Vocatives in DP languages disfavour articles and demonstratives:

- (38) ?*I ragazzi, venite qui!
the boys come here
'Come here, (the) boys!' (Italian; Longobardi, 1994, 626)
- (39) *Un/Qualche ragazzo, vieni qui!
a/some boy come here
'Come here, (a/some) boy!' (Italian; Longobardi, 1994, 627)
- (40) *The boys, come here!
- (41) *A/some boy, come here!
- (42) *This/that boy, come here!

Prediction: DEM should be fine in vocatives, but only when it is an adjectival article.

Vocative examples from OS

Always distal and immediately preceding weak adjective.

(43) Herro thie guodo
lord DEM.DIST good
(OSax.811.792)

(44) fro min thie guodo
lord my DEM.DIST good
(OSax.115.210)

16 examples. Always “DEM.DIST good”. Fossilized? But if so it’s fossilizing *something*...

Probably not “The Lord, the good one”, *pace* Allen (2006, 160).

Vocative examples from OE

Always distal and immediately preceding weak adjective.

- (45) Men ða leofestan
men DEM dearest-wk
(OEng.586.608 – Ælfric's Lives of Saints, Christmas Sermon)
- (46) min se leofeste sune
my DEM.DIST dearest son
(OEng.708.922 – Alcuin)
- (47) min se leofa magister
my DEM.DIST dear magister
(OEng.640.906 – Alexander's Letter)
- (48) min se halga Petrus
my DEM.DIST holy Peter
(OEng.496.724 – Blickling Homilies)

Vocative examples from OHG

Not easy to find examples with vocative in *Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*. But they do exist:

- (49) Gímma thiu wíza
 gem DEM white-wk
 (*Referenzkorpus Altdeutsch*; O_Otfr.Ev.1.5)

Summary of evidence

Language	OE (prose)	OE (poetry)	OS	OHG (Otfrid)	OHG (other)
POSS DEM	+	+	+	+	–
Postnominal DEM	+	+	+	+	+
Vocative DEM	+	+	+	+	??

Table: Evidence for adjectival articles in Early West Germanic

Interim summary

Evidence from:

- ▶ POSS plus DEM.DIST
- ▶ postnominal DEM.DIST
- ▶ DEM.DIST in vocatives

all points to the idea that, at least in early West Germanic, the original distal demonstrative had taken on a role as adjectival article – much like *hinn* in Old Icelandic.

Variable in all the early languages – little robust evidence after the ninth-tenth centuries.

West Germanic: distribution

Chambers & Trudgill (1998, 94):

when 'a linguistic feature exists in two or more parts of the region but those parts are separated from one another by an area in which a different, or opposing, feature occurs', we are dealing with a **relic feature**.

This seems to be the case for pre-1100 West Germanic.

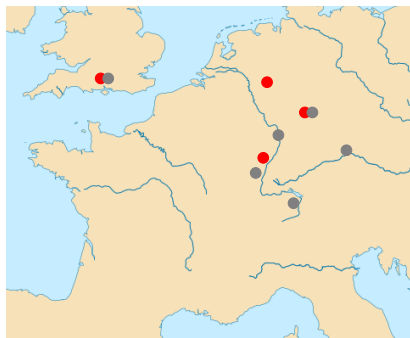


Figure: West Germanic texts pre-1100, VERY approximately. Points in red are texts with evidence for an adjectival article.

- ▶ “From a philological point of view, the definite determiner and the adjective can perhaps be seen to form an indivisible unit” (Ratkus, 2011, 141)
- ▶ Gothic also has an adjectival article!
- ▶ Thus: we can reconstruct an adjectival article for Proto-Germanic
- ▶ Challenge: different morphophonological realization (reflexes of *jainaz vs. *sa)

Thank you for listening!

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OE poetry: exceptions

Postnominal DEM without weak adjectives exists. (14 or so examples).

Postnominal weak adjectives without DEM exist:

- (50) se maga geonga
 DEM kinsman young-wk
 (YCOEP; cobeowul,83.2673.2189)

Bonus argument: 'Definiteness clash'

- (51) enon berage them hohon
 a mountain the high
 (OSax.406.580)

No line break or caesura between.

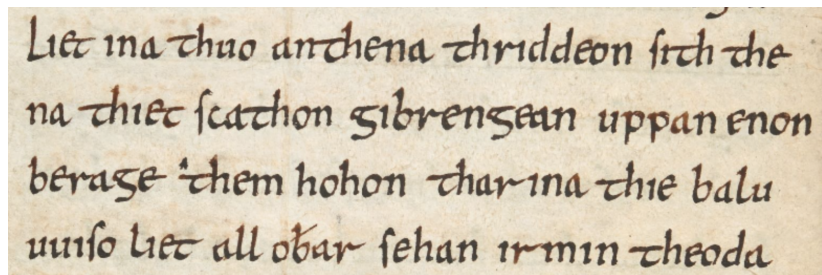


Figure: Heliand MS C, from f. 38v

- ▶ Gothic presents well-known challenges: the main text that we have at our disposal is a partial Bible translation, mostly of the New Testament, which remains very close to its Greek original.
- ▶ In the case of article use, however, Gothic on the whole does not follow Greek usage.
- ▶ New Testament Greek, like Modern Greek, exhibits polydefiniteness:

(52) hupo [**tou** pneumatos **tou** hagiou]
 by the.N.SG.GEN spirit.N.SG.GEN the.N.SG.GEN holy.N.SG.GEN
 ‘By the holy Spirit’
 (Luke 2:26; Ratkus, 2011, 139)

Gothic, 2

When rendering polydefinite constructions, the translator(s) of the Gothic Bible did not translate every Greek article using a distal demonstrative. Instead, “the translator, faced with the choice of eliminating one of the two determiners, chooses to delete the one before the noun while keeping the one preceding the adjective” (Ratkus, 2011, 140)

- (53) fram [ahmin **þamma** weihin]
from spirit.M.SG.DAT that.M.SG.DAT holy.M.SG.DAT
‘By the holy Spirit’
(Luke 2:26; Ratkus, 2011, 139)

- (54) hairdeis **sa** goda
shepherd.M.SG.NOM DEM.M.SG.NOM good.M.SG.NOM.WK
‘The good shepherd’
(John 10:11; Greek: *ho poimēn ho kalos* ‘the shepherd the good’)